placed it in a “very significant position to be able to bridge the gaps … provide the linkages … for a meaningful dialogue [between Tehran and Washington].” In effect, Khurshid was suggesting Indian mediation between Iran and the United States, a course similar, perhaps, to China’s 2013–2015 effort. But while India’s foreign minister was dropping hints of possible Indian mediation, Beijing undertook an impressive flurry of mediation activity sufficient to garner for China multiple expressions of Iranian gratitude, nothing of the sort emanated from New Delhi. Beijing beat New Delhi to the punch. Beijing’s support for Iran at this juncture went beyond rhetorical statements and included a whole slate of diplomatic efforts with both the United States and Iran. Of course, Beijing’s diplomacy benefited from its permanent membership on the Security Council. India had no such prominent platform.

Khurshid cited India’s willingness to work with Iran to build a modern port at Chabahar as evidence of New Delhi’s ability to partner with Iran despite possible American displeasure. “We have shared … with the United States of America our interest in Chabahar Port,” Khurshid explained. “In the normal course, the [American] reaction would be – hands off [i.e., a US “no”] as far as building infrastructure in Iran is concerned.” But, Khurshid continued:

> But that is not the reaction that we get [from the Americans]. We get a reaction that they [the Americans] understand. And they understand not simply because they want to be kind and considerate to India, but they understand because in 2014 when they leave Afghanistan, somebody has to fill the void, not of troops, because Afghans must look after their own security … but in terms of infrastructure and trade and finance backup they [Afghanistan] would need for stability in their society.